

[00:00:00.970] - Chris Johnstone

If I was to ask you, how old are you? You could answer that in a flash. But if I ask instead, how old is your family? What answer would you give? It's hard to put a starting date on something that stands beyond what we can see. But already in the shift from a personal focus to the larger self of our family, we're widening the period of time we look at. Just as landscape refers to an expanse of land we include in a view, I want to introduce the term "timescape" to refer to the period of time we give our attention to. Apart-hood is where we separate ourselves from what's around us, seeing ourselves in a little bubble,

[00:00:46.990] - Chris Johnstone

apart from the larger story of life. We can also do that with time. As psychologist Dr Rosie Jones describes:

[00:00:56.950] - Rosie Jones

Because we've been reduced to this very individualistic sense of self, it's really very hard to feel connected both to the wider society, but also stretching in both directions in time. But as a result, there's this poverty of connection. It isn't natural, I don't think, for us to feel so alienated from our ancestors.

[00:01:22.390] - Chris Johnstone

What Rosie is describing is apart-hood in time. Rather than seeing ourselves as part of a rich and ongoing story that extends far back and forward. The dominant mode of "business as usual", is to restrict our attention to a very narrow timescape that can leave people feeling alienated, as though they've lost the larger plot that gives life meaning, as well as robbing our lives of a sense of purpose. Narrow timescapes can also be a threat to our survival. I want to make a distinction between a hazard and a harm.

[00:02:01.330] - Chris Johnstone

A hazard is where there's a risk of harm, but it hasn't happened yet. So coming back to this image again, the person with the pickaxe is at the hazard stage where - even though it's reasonably foreseeable that their behaviour will lead to harm - if they're caught in the bubble of a narrow timescape, they don't register the danger. If they're digging for something valuable, they might get short term benefit, but a longer term cost. In the "business as usual" mode, decisionmaking is governed by this kind of short term thinking.

[00:02:40.390] - Chris Johnstone

In my work in the addiction field, I saw something similar happening with individuals. The attraction of the hit is very compelling. What gets missed out of view is the "s", for seeing the mess ahead. That's what's happening also with climate change and unsustainability in general. Unsustainable means it can't be sustained. That's obvious with this image. Yet to be able to recognise this more widely, we need to apply "seeing with new eyes" to time. This leads to an approach we call "Deep Time" introduced here by Joanna Macy.

[00:03:21.910] - Joanna Macy

There is an aspect of The Work That Reconnects that I am finding increasingly significant and enjoyable, and that is our work with time. "Deep Time", as we call it, which means, in essence, our relations with those who've gone before us and those who will come after us, here on Earth. I find this is ever more important. As we see the Industrial Growth Society accelerate its power and its decision making on an ever smaller piece of time and ever shorter time-frame. Short term thinking characterises the Industrial Growth Society, for the Industrial Growth Society determines its goals and measures its success in terms of the gains made in very short period -

[00:04:25.210] - Joanna Macy

A quarter, an economic quarter - and this must grow. Choices are made depending on how they will affect this short term. This is inherently destructive of human society and of the natural world, which is based on longer rhythms. Hence the value we find in the deep time exercises that have arisen from this work are really refreshing to the mind and inspiring to our vision. Not only does this assist us in

creating a larger time context for our lives, which gives us a sense of expansion of the spirit, it helps us feel the companionship of the past and future generations in the most heartening way, but it also can help steady us in the present moment.